

done through people.” But that didn’t stop ravenous government lawyers from devouring the company. Silicon Valley high-tech companies say they have a “policy” of never firing anyone. But they make abrupt policy changes when a couple of their top products suddenly lose their margins.

To protect yourself, the rule is:

Look for meaning in yourself, not in your job

The only sure way to avoid the pain of the bathtub test is to look inward—rather than at the bath water—to gauge your self-worth. You may have to remind yourself to do it. But you’ll be rewarded with a happier retirement and a more fulfilled life.

BUT I LIKE MY JOB

Some of us seem untouched by the career life cycle. We seem to find meaning in our work, even in a system that is manifestly unable to provide it.

I recently talked to a turned-on friend who runs his own business—selling replacement parts for high-tech measurement devices—without any employees. He works at home and keeps the inventory in his garage. His main job is order-taking, which he does by answering the phone. He sells a couple of million dollars’ worth of parts each year and manages to put an incredible 40 percent of it (pretax) in his bank account. Between phone calls he plays with his two small children. He loves chatting with his customers, his suppliers, and anyone else who happens to be around.

“Why the hell should I retire?” he asked me when I suggested it one day. “I’m in the prime of my career. I’m at peak earning power. I’m having a ball.”

My friend has felt that way for years, and he may never change. Sam Walton probably feels the same way. If you’re like them—having a ball in what is still a richly rewarding